LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

Why We Compare Ourselves to Others (And How to Stop)

Why your brain compares, why bronze medal winners look happier than silver, what happened when students cut social media, comparatives and natural English for envy and progress – and Jack's five tomatoes.



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · After you listen 🏅
Jack's tip: the only person you should compare your answers with is yourself!

0 Warm-up: My comparison check

fun · no points

Be honest! Tick everything that is true for you. 😊

- ☐ 📱 I feel worse after scrolling
- ☐ 👨‍👧 I compare myself to family
- ☐ 🎉 I'm happy for friends' success
- ☐ 🗣️ I compare my English a lot
- ☐ 🏠 I compare homes or salaries
- ☐ 🔁 I compare with my past self

My comparison score: _____ / 6

Guess! At the Olympics, who looked happier just after winning a medal?

(a) 🥈 silver winners (b) 🥉 bronze winners (c) they looked the same

🎧 **Check your guess at ⏱ 4:46**

Lucy: "Jack, you were a bronze medal gardener!" 🏅



💬 Let's talk

Say your answers out loud – or write them in your notebook.

1. Who do you compare yourself to most often?

2. Does comparing make you feel inspired or worse?

3. How is your English better than a year ago?

4. Why do people only post their best moments?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Then check at ⏱️ 1:41 · 4:46 · 14:43

- ☐ **1.** to compare
- ☐ **2.** envious
- ☐ **3.** to show off
- ☐ **4.** a highlight reel
- ☐ **5.** to measure up
- ☐ **6.** progress
- ☐ **7.** upward comparison
- ☐ **8.** downward comparison
- ☐ **9.** agony
- ☐ **10.** ecstasy

a) moving forward and getting better over time
b) terrible pain
c) to be as good as someone or something expects
d) wanting something that another person has
e) comparing yourself to someone who seems better off
f) extreme happiness
g) to look at two things to see how they're similar or different
h) a short video of only the best moments
i) comparing yourself to someone who seems worse off
j) to try to make people notice how good, rich or clever you are



Pronunciation corner 🔊 com-**PARE** · com-**PAR**-i-son · **EN**-vi-ous · **PRO**-gress (noun) · **EC**-sta-sy. Say it: *"I'm not as fluent as her – yet!"*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) Comparing is natural, but how we feel depends on who we compare with – so compare with your past self and celebrate your progress.
- (b) You should always compare yourself with the best people in the world.
- (c) Comparing yourself with others is always good for you.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

tomatoes · basket · medal · corner shop · seeds · birds · swimming pool · notebook

3 Know it or hear it?

quiz + listening · 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. "He's _____ than me at football."

(a) more better
(b) more good
(c) better

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

2. "She's _____ than her sister."

(a) taller
(b) more tall
(c) tallest

🧠 Grammar you know

3. "I'm not _____ good _____ her – yet!"

(a) so … that
(b) as … as
(c) more … than

🧠 Grammar you know

4. "I've made a lot of _____ this year."

(a) progresses
(b) progress
(c) a progress

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

5. "Comparison is the thief of joy." A thief is someone who…

(a) steals
(b) teaches
(c) sings

🧠 Everyday English

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. How long did it take before Jack had tomatoes?

(a) about two weeks
(b) about two months
(c) about a year

🎧 ⏱️ 0:05

7. Who wrote about "social comparison" in 1954?

(a) Leon Festinger
(b) Thomas Gilovich
(c) Melissa Hunt

🎧 ⏱️ 1:41

8. The medal study used TV footage from the Olympics in…

(a) Sydney, 2000
(b) London, 2012
(c) Barcelona, 1992

🎧 ⏱️ 4:46

9. In Hunt's study, students limited three apps to…

(a) ten minutes each per day
(b) one hour each per day
(c) ten minutes per week

🎧 ⏱️ 7:24

10. Who does Jack compare himself to most often?

(a) his neighbour
(b) his older brother
(c) other podcasters

🎧 ⏱️ 9:34

🍅 **Fun fact:** Jack was so proud of his tomatoes that he showed them to his mum – and to the man at the corner shop!

4 True or false? listening 6 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱️ times help you find the answer.

1	Jack watered his tomato plant every morning before work.	T	F	⏱️ 0:05
2	Festinger said we usually compare ourselves with people who are very different from us.	T	F	⏱️ 1:41
3	The students knew which medal each athlete had won.	T	F	⏱️ 4:46
4	Silver medal winners often compare themselves with the gold medal winner.	T	F	⏱️ 4:46
5	In Hunt's study, the students were put into two groups randomly.	T	F	⏱️ 7:24
6	The researchers knew exactly why using less social media helped.	T	F	⏱️ 7:24

5 Three comparison studies 🔍 listening 6 points



Which study is each sentence about? Write **A**, **B** or **C**. ⏱️ 1:41 · 4:46 · 7:24

A · Social comparison 📏
1954 · Leon Festinger, American psychologist

B · Silver vs bronze 🥈🥉
1995 · Medvec, Madey & Gilovich, Cornell

C · Less social media 📱
2018 · Melissa Hunt and colleagues, Univ. of Pennsylvania

1	Students rated athletes' faces from agony to ecstasy.	☐
2	People have a natural need to know how they're doing.	☐
3	143 university students took part for three weeks.	☐
4	The biggest improvements were in the students who felt worst at the start.	☐
5	Third place looked happier than second place.	☐
6	We usually compare ourselves with people who are similar to us.	☐

6 Looking up or looking down? new! upward or downward 6 points



Is each thought an **upward** comparison (with someone better off) or a **downward** one (with someone worse off)? ⏱️ 1:41 · 4:46



1. 🥈 "I was so close to gold!"	☐ ⬆️ upward	☐ ⬇️ downward
2. 🥉 "Wow – at least I got a medal!"	☐ ⬆️ upward	☐ ⬇️ downward
3. 🍅 "My neighbour grew a whole basket."	☐ ⬆️ upward	☐ ⬇️ downward
4. 😏 "At least I'm not as bad as him."	☐ ⬆️ upward	☐ ⬇️ downward
5. 📱 "She sounds like a native speaker. I sound terrible."	☐ ⬆️ upward	☐ ⬇️ downward
6. 🏃 "Some runners didn't even finish the race."	☐ ⬆️ upward	☐ ⬇️ downward

7 "I just don't measure up!" listening 10 points



A niece is learning English, and she feels a bit down after watching videos online. Listen at ⏱ 12:20 and write **one word** in each gap (1–10). The breakdown at ⏱ 13:30 can help.



LUCY
Hi, Uncle Jack. Can I ask you something? Do you think my English is 1 _____?



JACK
Bad? Not at all. Why do you ask?



LUCY
I've just been watching a girl my age online. Her English is 2 _____. She sounds like a native speaker. 3 _____ to her, I sound terrible.



JACK
4 _____ on. How long has she been learning?



LUCY
I don't know. Maybe she grew up abroad.

JACK
Exactly. You don't know her story. And I 5 _____ she didn't get it right the first time either.





LUCY
I suppose so. But I just don't 6 _____ up.

JACK
Listen. Do you remember the message you sent me in English last 7 _____?





LUCY
Oh, don't 8 _____ me. It was full of mistakes.

JACK
And today you're explaining your feelings to me in English, without even thinking about it. That's real progress.





LUCY
Hmm. When you put it like that, I feel a bit better.

JACK
The grass is always 9 _____, you know. Keep your eyes on your own 10 _____.





LUCY
Thanks. I needed to hear that.

8 Phrases to steal expressions 4 points

Match each phrase from the chat (1–4) to its meaning (a–d). ⏱ 13:30

- ☐ **1.** "Hang on."
- ☐ **2.** "I bet..."
- ☐ **3.** "Don't remind me!"
- ☐ **4.** "When you put it like that..."

a) I'm almost sure...
b) When you explain it in that way...
c) Wait a moment.
d) That's embarrassing – I'd prefer to forget it!

9 Comparison idioms

idioms · 6 points

Complete each sentence with a word from the box. ⏱️ 14:43 · 17:06



apples · envy · greener · Joneses · show-off · thief

1. 🌱 Other people's lives always look better. The grass is always _____.
2. 🚗 They bought a new car just to keep up with the _____.
3. 🍎 A small village café and a famous restaurant? That's comparing _____ and oranges.
4. 😢 Comparing yourself all the time steals your happiness. Comparison is the _____ of joy.
5. 💚 When she saw my new bike, she was green with _____.
6. 💰 He always talks about his money and his car. He's such a _____.



Jack's tip: Envious = you want what someone else has. **Jealous** can mean the same in everyday English (*"I'm so jealous of your holiday!"*) – but it can also mean afraid of losing someone you love to another person. 💚

10 Compare it right!

new! comparatives · 6 points

Write the correct form of the word in brackets. ⏱️ 18:07



📏 **short words + -er:** tall → taller · big → bigger
good → better (never "more better"!)

📐 **long words: more + word:** more confident
⚖️ **not as + word + as:** not as fast as

1. 🍅 Five tomatoes? That's much _____ than none! **(good)**
2. 🧺 My neighbour's basket was _____ than mine. **(big)**
3. 🗣️ She's _____ than she was last year. **(confident)**
4. 🏃 I'm not _____ my brother. **(as / fast)**
5. 🌍 My English isn't _____ hers – yet! **(as / fluent)**
6. 📅 _____ with last year, my English is much better. **(compare)**

🥈 → 🥉 **Think like a bronze medal winner!** (no points)

Lucy's third tip: don't only think "I'm not as good as them" – think about how far you've come and what you already have. Turn each silver thought into a bronze thought. ⏱️ 10:03

🥈 "I only grew five tomatoes."	🥉 *"I grew five tomatoes in my very first year – on a balcony!"*
🥈 "I still make mistakes when I speak."	🥉 _____
🥈 "My friend runs faster than me."	🥉 _____
🥈 "I can't understand every word of this episode."	🥉 _____

11 Say it better

common mistakes · 10 points

These sentences sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 18:07

😐 1. "He is more better than me." 😊 _____

😐 2. "I am not good like her." 😊 _____

😐 3. "Compare with him, I am bad at football." 😊 _____

😐 4. "I made a lot of progresses this year." 😊 _____

😐 5. "My English is very bad." 😊 _____



Lucy's tip: "Yet" is a very powerful word for learners: *"My English isn't as fluent as hers – **yet**."* And **progress** is uncountable: *some progress, a lot of progress, great progress* – never "a progress". ✨

🔁 Then and now

compare with your past self · no points



Jack's first tip: don't ask "Am I as good as her?" – ask "Am I better than I was six months ago?" Write three things. ⏱️ 10:03

⏮️ A year ago, I couldn't *understand a podcast in English.* ⏭️ Now I can *understand most of this episode!*

⏮️ A year ago, I couldn't _____ ⏭️ Now I can _____

⏮️ A year ago, I couldn't _____ ⏭️ Now I can _____

💚 **Turn envy into information** (no points) Jack's second tip: when you feel envious, ask "What exactly do I want?" Then the feeling becomes a signal, not a punishment. ⏱️ 10:03

😒 I'm envious of...	🤔 What I really want is...	👣 One small step:
my friend's fitness	*to be more active*	*a 15-minute walk every day*

🎉 Be happy for them!

Jack's third tip · no points



When a friend does well, say "Congratulations, you deserve it!" – and mean it. Their success doesn't take anything away from you. Write a kind reply to each message. ⏱️ 10:03

Congratulations – you deserve it! · **That's brilliant news!** · **I'm so happy for you!** · **Well done – you worked so hard for it!**

📩 "I passed my driving test!" 💬 *"Congratulations – you deserve it!"*

📩 "I got the job!" 💬 _____

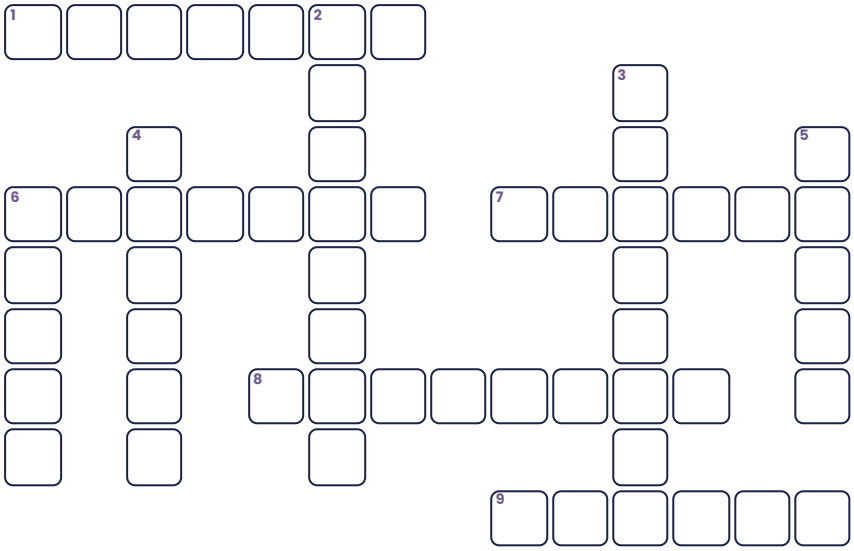
📩 "I finished my first 10 km race!" 💬 _____

📩 "My teacher says my English is much better now!" 💬 _____

12 Garden & medals crossword 🧩 puzzle 10 points



Read the clues and write the words in the grid (1 point each). The number in brackets is the number of letters. Letters that cross help you!



➡️ Across

1 Jack's little garden was on his ___. (7)

6 Jack compares himself to his very organised older ___. (7)

7 Third place – but often happier than second: a ___ medal. (6)

8 Red fruits that many people think are vegetables – Jack grew five of them. (8)

9 In the photo, the neighbour was holding a huge ___. (6)

⬇️ Down

2 The neighbour writes down everything that went wrong in his garden ___. (8)

3 Moving forward and getting better (it's uncountable!): ___. (8)

4 "I nearly didn't get a medal at all – I'm on the ___!" (6)

5 The neighbour gave Jack a little bag of ___ to try next year. (5)

6 In the neighbour's first year, the ___ ate everything! (5)

13 Jack's tomatoes 🍅 listening 6 points



Listen at ⏱️ 0:05 and ⏱️ 20:39. Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes.

☐ ✍️ The neighbour showed Jack where he writes down all his mistakes.

☐ 🍅 Jack's plant finally gave him five small, red, perfect ones – he was so proud.

☐ 🌱 He gave Jack something to plant – and Jack plans to grow eight next year.

☐ 📱 That evening, he saw his neighbour's amazing garden photo.

☐ 0️⃣ "In my first year, I grew none – not a single one!"

☐ 🗑️ Taking his rubbish downstairs, Jack met the neighbour in the garden.

Think about it 💭 (no points) Why wasn't Jack's comparison fair? Use **apples and oranges** or **highlight reel**.

14 Your turn

writing · 8 points

2 points for each good sentence.



A. Who I compare myself to 🤔

Who is it, and how does it make you feel? *e.g. "I sometimes compare myself to my cousin, because she's more confident than me."*

B. My progress 🌱

Compare your English today with a year ago. *e.g. "Compared with last year, I'm much more confident. I'm not as fluent as I want to be – yet!"*

⏱️ My past-self week

your 7-day mission

One small step every day. The only person you need to be better than is the person you were yesterday!



Day	Small step	What I noticed	Done?
1	📩 find an old English message		☐
2	🎙️ record one minute in English		☐
3	📝 rewrite the old message		☐
4	🔕 mute one account		☐
5	🎉 congratulate a friend		☐
6	🏅 three things I already have		☐
7	🔁 listen to Day 2 again		☐

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

📏 COMPARE
Compared to last year...
I'm not as ... as ... yet.
He's better than me.

💚 FEELINGS
I'm a bit envious.
I don't measure up.
green with envy

🌱 PERSPECTIVE
The grass is always greener.
apples and oranges
just a highlight reel

🎉 BE KIND
Congratulations – you deserve it!
I've made a lot of progress.
I'm still learning.

Can you do it now?

I can...	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
explain upward and downward comparison.	😟	🙂	😄
explain why bronze winners can feel happier than silver winners.	😟	🙂	😄
use comparatives: better, taller, more confident, not as ... as.	😟	🙂	😄
talk about my progress without saying "My English is very bad".	😟	🙂	😄



Share it with us! Find something old you made in English, compare it with today – and tell us in the comments! Have you made **a lot of progress**? Is **the grass always greener**? And if you know how to stop birds eating tomatoes, Jack needs your help! 🐦🍅

Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

Guess: b – bronze winners looked clearly happier. · Predict: **swimming pool** 🏊 isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words · 2 · The big idea

1 g · 2 d · 3 j · 4 h · 5 c · 6 a · 7 e · 8 i · 9 b · 10 f
Big idea: a (2 points)

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 c · 2 a · 3 b · 4 b · 5 a · 6 b · 7 a · 8 c · 9 a · 10 b

4 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (people who are similar to us) · 3 F (they didn't know) · 4 T · 5 T · 6 F (they couldn't say exactly why)

5 · Three studies · 6 · Up or down?

5: 1 B · 2 A · 3 C · 4 C · 5 B · 6 A
6: 1 upward · 2 downward · 3 upward · 4 downward · 5 upward · 6 downward

7 · "I just don't measure up!"

1 bad · 2 perfect · 3 Compared · 4 Hang · 5 bet · 6 measure · 7 year · 8 remind · 9 greener · 10 path

8 · Phrases to steal

1 c · 2 a · 3 d · 4 b

9 · Idioms · 10 · Compare it right!

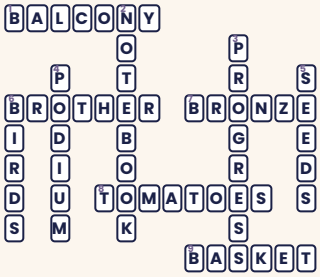
9: 1 greener · 2 Joneses · 3 apples · 4 thief · 5 envy · 6 show-off
10: 1 better · 2 bigger · 3 more confident · 4 as fast as · 5 as fluent as · 6 Compared

11 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 He's better than me. / He's better than I am. · 2 I'm not as good as her. · 3 Compared with him, I'm not very good at football. / He's much better at football than me. · 4 I've made a lot of progress this year. · 5 I'm still learning. / My English is getting better every day.

12 · Crossword

Across: 1 balcony · 6 brother · 7 bronze · 8 tomatoes · 9 basket
Down: 2 notebook · 3 progress · 4 podium · 5 seeds · 6 birds



13 · Jack's tomatoes · 14 · Your turn

1 🍅 five tomatoes · 2 📱 the basket photo · 3 🗑️ met the neighbour · 4 0️⃣ "I grew none" · 5 ✍️ the notebook · 6 🌱 seeds – eight next year
Think about it, e.g.: he compared his first year with his neighbour's twelfth – apples and oranges. The basket was the neighbour's highlight reel.
14: your own answers – 2 points per good sentence.

Your score

90–100 🏆 **Gold medal!** · 70–89 🥉 **On the podium!** · 50–69 🍅 **Five perfect tomatoes** · 0–49 🌱 **Keep growing – try again!**

Enjoyed this worksheet? 🎉

Scan to subscribe to **Daily Speak English** – new episodes with Jack and Lucy. And remember: the only person you really need to be better than is the person you were yesterday. Be proud of your five tomatoes! 🍅💜
More free worksheets: **dailyspeakenglish.github.io/worksheets**



Free for personal and classroom use. Please share the page link, not the file.